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Benefits scandal discussed in Brussels: 'This was not China, but the Netherlands'



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"This didn't happen in China, but in the Netherlands." The surprise resonated in the words of Saskia Bricmont, the Belgian MEP for the Greens, during the debate on the childcare benefits scandal in the Netherlands.

That debate was on the agenda in the European Parliament on Wednesday evening. At first glance, it might seem strange that a Dutch issue is being discussed in Strasbourg, but according to politicians, there are lessons to be learned from the affair for other EU countries.

Samira Rafaela, MEP for D66, for example, already asked the European Commission questions last year regarding the childcare benefits scandal. In tonight's debate, she

also raised the point that the Netherlands was breaking European and international laws, for instance through the Tax and Customs Administration's controversial algorithm.

Also an EU topic

Rafaela is pleased that the subject is now also being addressed in the European arena. "As a member of the EU, you don't just enjoy the benefits. You also have a duty of care towards your citizens," she says. According to her, there is even sufficient reason for the Commission to initiate a so-called infringement procedure and reprimand the Netherlands.

European Commissioner for Equality Helena Dalli attended the debate. According to her, the benefits scandal exposed the risk of ethnic profiling, but the Dutch government is now working to rectify these mistakes.

However, this does not seem to allay the major concerns of most MEPs. Many countries work with algorithms, and Europol also uses software to track down criminals. "Every corner of the EU must be safe for citizens, regardless of the color of their skin," said Evin Encir, the Swedish MEP for the Social Democrats.

Commission must get to work

According to the MEPs, the Commission must do two things. Firstly, it must be better monitored whether countries are doing everything possible to tackle discrimination. Secondly, the mistakes of the childcare benefits scandal must also be taken into account in the new law governing artificial intelligence.

Some MEPs advocate that data should no longer be used for investigations. Other MEPs, such as Agnes Jongerius of the PvdA, argue that people's dual nationality should no longer be taken into account in the data.

European Commissioner Dalli concluded the debate and emphasized that the errors in the Netherlands were eventually noticed. The Commission will continue to closely monitor whether the affected parents will be compensated in the coming period.

More than a thousand children of victims of childcare benefits scandal removed from their homes.

